

Chapter IX

In Which the Unknown of the Hostelry of Les Medici Loses His Incognito



HIS officer, who was sleeping, or preparing to sleep, was, notwithstanding his careless air, charged with a serious responsibility.

Lieutenant of the king's musketeers, he commanded all the company which came from Paris, and that company consisted of a hundred and twenty men; but, with the exception of the twenty of whom we have spoken, the other hundred were engaged in guarding the queen-mother, and more particularly the cardinal.

Monsignor Giulio Mazzini economized the travelling expenses of his guards; he consequently used the king's, and that largely, since he took fifty of them for himself—a peculiarity which would not have failed to strike any one unacquainted with the usages of that court.

That which would still further have appeared, if not inconvenient, at least extraordinary, to a stranger, was, that the side of the castle destined for monsieur le cardinal was brilliant, light and cheerful. The musketeers there mounted guard before every door, and allowed no one to enter, except the couriers, who, even while he was travelling, followed the cardinal for the carrying on of his correspondence.

Twenty men were on duty with the queen-mother; thirty rested, in order to relieve their companions the next day.

On the king's side, on the contrary, were darkness, silence, and solitude. When once the doors were closed, there was no longer an appearance of

royalty. All the servitors had by degrees retired. Monsieur le Prince had sent to know if his majesty required his attendance; and on the customary 'No' of the lieutenant of musketeers, who was habituated to the question and the reply, all appeared to sink into the arms of sleep, as if in the dwelling of a good citizen.

And yet it was possible to hear from the side of the house occupied by the young king the music of the banquet, and to see the windows of the great hall richly illuminated.

Ten minutes after his installation in his apartment, Louis XIV had been able to learn, by movement much more distinguished than marked his own leaving, the departure of the cardinal, who, in his turn, sought his bedroom, accompanied by a large escort of ladies and gentlemen.

Besides, to perceive this movement, he had nothing to do but look out at his window, the shutters of which had not been closed.

His eminence crossed the court, conducted by Monsieur, who himself held a flambeau; then followed the queen-mother, to whom Madame familiarly gave her arm; and both walked chatting away, like two old friends.

Behind these two couples filed nobles, ladies, pages and officers; the flambeaux gleamed over the whole court, like the moving reflections of a conflagration. Then the noise of steps and voices became lost in the upper floors of the castle.

No one was then thinking of the king, who, leaning on his elbow at his window, had sadly seen pass away all that light, and heard that noise die off—no, not one, if it was not that unknown of the hostelry des Medici, whom we have seen go out, enveloped in his cloak.

He had come straight up to the castle, and had, with his melancholy countenance, wandered round and round the palace, from which the people had not yet departed; and finding that on one guarded the great entrance, or the porch, seeing that the soldiers of Monsieur were fraternizing with the royal soldiers—that is to say, swallowing Beaugency at discretion, or rather indiscretion—the unknown penetrated through the crowd, then ascended to the court, and came to the landing of the staircase leading to the cardinal's apartment.

What, according to all probability, induced him to direct his steps that way, was the splendour of the flambeaux, and the busy air of the pages

'Uncle,' replied the young king, 'I render you my thanks for your cordial hospitality.'

Gaston bowed to his nephew, embraced him, and then went out.

Of the twenty musketeers who had accompanied the king, ten reconducted Monsieur to the reception-rooms, which were not yet empty, notwithstanding the king had retired.

The ten others were posted by their officer, who himself explored, in five minutes, all the localities, with that cold and certain glance which not even habit gives unless that glance belongs to genius.

Then, when all were placed, he chose as his headquarters the antechamber, in which he found a large fauteuil, a lamp, some wine, some water, and some dry bread.

He refreshed his lamp, drank half a glass of wine, curled his lip with a smile full of expression, installed himself in his large armchair, and made preparations for sleeping.

And he stopped. The rest, both behind and before him, stopped likewise.

'The duc, sire,' continued Gaston, 'was nearly were I stand: he was walking in the same direction as your majesty; M. de Loignac was exactly where your lieutenant of musketeers is; M. de Saint-Maline and his majesty's ordinaries were behind him and around him. It was here that he was struck.'

The king turned towards his officer, and saw something like a cloud pass over his martial and daring countenance.

'Yes, from behind!' murmured the lieutenant, with a gesture of supreme disdain. And he endeavoured to resume the march, as if ill at ease at being between walls formerly defiled by treachery.

But the king, who appeared to wish to be informed, was disposed to give another look at this dismal spot.

Gaston perceived his nephew's desire.

'Look, sire,' said he, taking a flambeau from the hands of M. de Saint-Remy, 'this is where he fell. There was a bed there, the curtains of which he tore with catching at them.'

'Why does the floor seem hollowed out at this spot?' asked Louis.

'Because it was here the blood flowed,' replied Gaston; 'the blood penetrated deeply into the oak, and it was only by cutting it out that they succeeded in making it disappear. And even then,' added Gaston, pointing the flambeau to the spot, 'even then this red stain resisted all the attempts made to destroy it.'

Louis XIV raised his head. Perhaps he was thinking of that bloody trace that had once been shown him at the Louvre, and which, as a pendant to that of Blois, had been made there one day by the king his father with the blood of Concini.

'Let us go on,' said he.

The march was resumed promptly; for emotion, no doubt, had given to the voice of the young prince a tone of command which was not customary with him. When he arrived at the apartment destined for the king, which communicated not only with the little passage we have passed through, but further with the great staircase leading to the court,—

'Will your majesty,' said Gaston, 'condescend to occupy this apartment, all unworthy as it is to receive you?'

and domestics. But he was stopped short by a presented musket and the cry of the sentinel.

'Where are you going, my friend?' asked the soldier.

'I am going to the king's apartment,' replied the unknown, haughtily, but tranquilly.

The soldier called one of his eminence's officers, who, in the tone in which a youth in office directs a solicitor to a minister, let fall these words:

'The other staircase, in front.'

And the officer, without further notice of the unknown, resumed his interrupted conversation.

The stranger, without reply, directed his steps towards the staircase pointed out to him. On this side there was no noise, there were no more flambeaux.

Obscurity, through which a sentinel glided like a shadow; silence, which permitted him to hear the sound of his own footsteps, accompanied with the jingling of his spurs upon the stone slabs.

This guard was one of the twenty musketeers appointed for attendance upon the king, and who mounted guard with the stiffness and consciousness of a statue.

'Who goes there?' said the guard.

'A friend,' replied the unknown.

'What do you want?'

'To speak to the king.'

'Do you, my dear monsieur? That's not very likely.'

'Why not?'

'Because the king has gone to bed.'

'Gone to bed already?'

'Yes.'

'No matter: I must speak to him.'

'And I tell you that is impossible.'

'And yet—'

'Go back!'

'Do you require the word?'

'I have no account to render to you. Stand back!'

And this time the soldier accompanied his word with a threatening gesture; but the unknown stirred no more than if his feet had taken root.

'Monsieur le mousquetaire,' said he, 'are you a gentleman?'

'I have that honour.'

'Very well! I also am one; and between gentlemen some consideration ought to be observed.'

The soldier lowered his arms, overcome by the dignity with which these words were pronounced.

'Speak, monsieur,' said he; 'and if you ask me anything in my power—'

'Thank you. You have an officer, have you not?'

'Our lieutenant? Yes, monsieur.'

'Well, I wish to speak to him.'

'Oh, that's a different thing. Come up, monsieur.'

The unknown saluted the soldier in a lofty fashion, and ascended the staircase; whilst a cry, 'Lieutenant, a visit!' transmitted from sentinel to sentinel, preceded the unknown, and disturbed the slumbers of the officer.

Dragging on his boot, rubbing his eyes, and hooking his cloak, the lieutenant made three steps towards the stranger.

'What can I do to serve you, monsieur?' asked he.

'You are the officer on duty, lieutenant of the musketeers, are you?'

'I have that honour,' replied the officer.

'Monsieur, I must absolutely speak to the king.'

The lieutenant looked attentively at the unknown, and in that look, he saw all he wished to see—that is to say, a person of high distinction in an ordinary dress.

'I do not suppose you to be mad,' replied he; 'and yet you seem to me to be in a condition to know, monsieur, that people do not enter a king's apartments in this manner without his consent.'

'He will consent.'

'Monsieur, permit me to doubt that. The king has retired this quarter of an hour; he must be now undressing. Besides, the word is given.'

'When he knows who I am, he will recall the word.'

The officer was more and more surprised, more and more subdued.

'If I consent to announce you, may I at least know whom to announce, monsieur?'

'You will announce His Majesty Charles II., King of England, Scotland, and Ireland.'

At these words, which produced the effect of a peal of thunder, prevailing over the orchestra, the singing and the buzz of the promenaders, the cardinal and the queen-mother looked at each other with surprise.

Louis XIV, pale, but resolved, supported as he was by that intuition of his own thought which he had found in the mind of the officer of musketeers, and which he had just manifested by the order given, arose from his chair, and took a step towards the door.

'Are you going, my son?' said the queen, whilst Mazarin satisfied himself with interrogating by a look which might have appeared mild if it had not been so piercing.

'Yes, madame,' replied the king; 'I am fatigued, and, besides, wish to write this evening.'

A smile stole over the lips of the minister, who appeared, by a bend of the head, to give the king permission.

Monsieur and Madame hastened to give orders to the officers who presented themselves.

The king bowed, crossed the hall, and gained the door, where a hedge of twenty musketeers awaited him. At the extremity of this hedge stood the officer, impassible, with his drawn sword in his hand. The king passed, and all the crowd stood on tip-toe, to have one more look at him.

Ten musketeers, opening the crowd of the ante-chambers and the steps, made way for his majesty. The other ten surrounded the king and Monsieur, who had insisted upon accompanying his majesty. The domestics walked behind. This little cortège escorted the king to the chamber destined for him. The apartment was the same that had been occupied by Henry III during his sojourn in the States.

Monsieur had given his orders. The musketeers, led by their officer, took possession of the little passage by which one wing of the castle communicates with the other. This passage was commenced by a small square ante-chamber, dark even in the finest days. Monsieur stopped Louis XIV.

'You are passing now, sire,' said he, 'the very spot where the Duc de Guise received the first stab of the poniard.'

The king was ignorant of all historical matters; he had heard of the fact, but he knew nothing of the localities or the details.

'Ah!' said he with a shudder.

appear to comprehend any of the supplications conveyed by the looks of her son.

From this moment, music, lights, flowers, beauties, all became odious and insipid to Louis XIV. After he had a hundred times bitten his lips, stretched his legs and his arms like a well-brought-up child, who, without daring to gape, exhausts all the modes of evincing his weariness—after having uselessly again implored his mother and the minister, he turned a despairing look towards the door, that is to say, towards liberty.

At this door, in the embrasure of which he was leaning, he saw, standing out strongly, a figure with a brown and lofty countenance, an aquiline nose, a stern but brilliant eye, gray and long hair, a black moustache, the true type of military beauty, whose gorget, more sparkling than a mirror, broke all the reflected lights which concentrated upon it, and sent them back as lightning. This officer wore his gray hat with its long red plumes upon his head, a proof that he was called there by his duty, and not by his pleasure. If he had been brought thither by his pleasure—if he had been a courtier instead of a soldier, as pleasure must always be paid for at the same price—he would have held his hat in his hand.

That which proved still better that this officer was upon duty, and was accomplishing a task to which he was accustomed, was, that he watched, with folded arms, remarkable indifference, and supreme apathy, the joys and ennuis of this fete. Above all, he appeared, like a philosopher, and all old soldiers are philosophers,—he appeared above all to comprehend the ennui infinitely better than the joys; but in the one he took his part, knowing very well how to do without the other.

Now, he was leaning, as we have said, against the carved door-frame when the melancholy, weary eyes of the king, by chance, met his.

It was not the first time, as it appeared, that the eyes of the officer had met those eyes, and he was perfectly acquainted with the expression of them; for, as soon as he had cast his own look upon the countenance of Louis XIV, and had read by it what was passing in his heart—that is to say, all the ennui that oppressed him—all the timid desire to go out which agitated him,—he perceived he must render the king a service without his commanding it,—almost in spite of himself. Boldly, therefore, as if he had given the word of command to cavalry in battle, ‘On the king’s service!’ cried he, in a clear, sonorous voice.

The officer uttered a cry of astonishment, drew back, and there might be seen upon his pallid countenance one of the most poignant emotions that ever an energetic man endeavoured to drive back to his heart.

‘Oh, yes, sire; in fact,’ said he, ‘I ought to have recognized you.’

‘You have seen my portrait, then?’

‘No, sire.’

‘Or else you have seen me formerly at court, before I was driven from France?’

‘No, sire, it is not even that.’

‘How then could you have recognized me, if you have never seen my portrait or my person?’

‘Sire, I saw his majesty your father at a terrible moment.’

‘The day—’

‘Yes.’

A dark cloud passed over the brow of the prince; then, dashing his hand across it, ‘Do you see any difficulty in announcing me?’ said he.

‘Sire, pardon me,’ replied the officer, ‘but I could not imagine a king under so simple an exterior; and yet I had the honour to tell your majesty just now that I had seen Charles I. But pardon me, monsieur; I will go and inform the king.’

But returning after going a few steps, ‘Your majesty is desirous, without doubt, that this interview should be a secret?’ said he.

‘I do not require it; but if it were possible to preserve it—’

‘It is possible, sire, for I can dispense with informing the first gentleman on duty; but, for that, your majesty must please to consent to give up your sword.’

‘True, true; I had forgotten that no one armed is permitted to enter the chamber of a king of France.’

‘Your majesty will form an exception, if you wish it; but then I shall avoid my responsibility by informing the king’s attendant.’

‘Here is my sword, monsieur. Will you now please to announce me to his majesty?’

‘Instantly, sire.’ And the officer immediately went and knocked at the door of communication, which the valet opened to him.

‘His Majesty the King of England!’ said the officer.

‘His Majesty the King of England!’ replied the valet de chambre.

At these words a gentleman opened the folding-doors of the king's apartment, and Louis XIV was seen, without hat or sword, and his point open, advancing with signs of the greatest surprise.

'You, my brother—you at Blois!' cried Louis XIV, dismissing with a gesture both the gentlemen and the valet de chambre, who passed out into the next apartment.

'Sire,' replied Charles II., 'I was going to Paris, in the hope of seeing your majesty; when report informed me of your approaching arrival in this city. I therefore prolonged my abode here, having something very particular to communicate to you.'

'Will this closet suit you, my brother?'

'Perfectly well, sire; for I think no one can hear us here.'

'I have dismissed my gentleman and my watcher; they are in the next chamber. There, behind that partition, is a solitary closet, looking into the ante-chamber, and in that ante-chamber you found nobody but a solitary officer, did you?'

'No, sire.'

'Well, then, speak, my brother; I listen to you.'

'Sire, I commence, and entreat your majesty to have pity on the misfortunes of our house.'

The king of France coloured, and drew his chair closer to that of the king of England.

'Sire,' said Charles II., 'I have no need to ask if your majesty is acquainted with the details of my deplorable history.'

Louis XIV blushed, this time more strongly than before; then, stretching forth his hand to that of the king of England, 'My brother,' said he, 'I am ashamed to say so, but the cardinal scarcely ever speaks of political affairs before me. Still more, formerly I used to get Laporte, my valet de chambre, to read historical subjects to me; but he put a stop to these readings, and took away Laporte from me. So that I beg my brother Charles to tell me all those matters as to a man who knows nothing.'

'Well, sire, I think that by taking things from the beginning I shall have a better chance of touching the heart of your majesty.'

'Speak on, my brother—speak on.'

'You know, sire, that being called in 1650 to Edinburgh, during Cromwell's expedition into Ireland, I was crowned at Scone. A year after,

But princes are thus constituted. The gods, too, were just like this in Olympus. Diana and Venus, no doubt, abused the beautiful Alcmena and poor Io, when they condescended for distraction's sake, to speak, amidst nectar and ambrosia, of mortal beauties, at the table of Jupiter.

Fortunately, Louise was so bent in her reverential salute, that she did not catch either Madame's words or the king's smile. In fact, if the poor child, who had so much good taste as alone to have chosen to dress herself in white amidst all her companions—if that dove's heart, so easily accessible to painful emotions, had been touched by the cruel words of Madame, or the egotistical cold smile of the king, it would have annihilated her.

And Montalais herself, the girl of ingenious ideas, would not have attempted to recall her to life; for ridicule kills beauty even.

But fortunately, as we have said, Louise, whose ears were buzzing, and her eyes veiled by timidity,—Louise saw nothing and heard nothing; and the king, who had still his attention directed to the conversation of the cardinal and his uncle, hastened to return to them.

He came up just at the moment Mazarin terminated by saying: 'Mary, as well as her sisters, has just set off for Brouage. I make them follow the opposite bank of the Loire to that along which we have travelled; and if I calculate their progress correctly, according to the orders I have given, they will to-morrow be opposite Blois.'

These words were pronounced with that tact—that measure, that distinctness of tone, of intention, and reach—which made del Signor Giulio Mazarini the first comedian in the world.

It resulted that they went straight to the heart of Louis XIV, and the cardinal, on turning round at the simple noise of the approaching footsteps of his majesty, saw the immediate effect of them upon the countenance of his pupil, an effect betrayed to the keen eyes of his eminence by a slight increase of colour. But what was the ventilation of such a secret to him whose craft had for twenty years deceived all the diplomatists of Europe?

From the moment the young king heard these last words, he appeared as if he had received a poisoned arrow in his heart. He could not remain quiet in a place, but cast around an uncertain, dead, and aimless look over the assembly. He with his eyes interrogated his mother more than twenty times: but she, given up to the pleasure of conversing with her sister-in-law, and likewise constrained by the glance of Mazarin, did not

'Stop a bit, stop a bit, dear aunt!' said the king, smiling; 'for the second part of my sentence will serve as a corrective to the first. Well, my dear aunt, some of them appear old and others ugly, thanks to their ten-year-old fashions.'

'But, sire, Blois is only five days' journey from Paris.'

'Yes, that is it,' said the king; 'two years behind for each day.'

'Indeed! do you really think so? Well, that is strange! It never struck me.'

'Now, look, aunt,' said Louis XIV, drawing still nearer to Mazarin, under the pretext of gaining a better point of view, 'look at that simple white dress by the side of those antiquated specimens of finery, and those pretentious coiffures. She is probably one of my mother's maids of honour, though I don't know her.'

'Ah! ah! my dear nephew!' replied Madame, laughing; 'permit me to tell you that your divinatory science is at fault for once. The young lady you honour with your praise is not a Parisian, but a Blaisoise.'

'Oh, aunt!' replied the king with a look of doubt.

'Come here, Louise,' said Madame.

And the fair girl, already known to you under that name, approached them, timid, blushing, and almost bent beneath the royal glance.

'Mademoiselle Louise Françoise de la Beaume le Blanc, the daughter of the Marquise de la Vallière,' said Madame, ceremoniously.

The young girl bowed with so much grace, mingled with the profound timidity inspired by the presence of the king, that the latter lost, while looking at her, a few words of the conversation of Monsieur and the cardinal.

'Daughter-in-law,' continued Madame, 'of M. de Saint-Remy, my maître d'hôtel, who presided over the confection of that excellent daube truffée which your majesty seemed so much to appreciate.'

No grace, no youth, no beauty, could stand out against such a presentation. The king smiled. Whether the words of Madame were a pleasure, or uttered in all innocence, they proved the pitiless immolation of everything that Louis had found charming or poetic in the young girl. Mademoiselle de la Vallière, for Madame and, by rebound, for the king, was, for a moment, no more than the daughter of a man of a superior talent over dined truffées.

wounded in one of the provinces he had usurped, Cromwell returned upon us. To meet him was my object; to leave Scotland was my wish.'

'And yet,' interrupted the young king, 'Scotland is almost your native country, is it not, my brother?'

'Yes, but the Scots were cruel compatriots for me, sire; they had forced me to forsake the religion of my fathers; they had hung Lord Montrose, the most devoted of my servants, because he was not a Covenantant; and as the poor martyr, to whom they had offered a favour when dying, had asked that his body might be cut into as many pieces as there are cities in Scotland, in order that evidence of his fidelity might be met with everywhere, I could not leave one city, or go into another, without passing under some fragments of a body which had acted, fought, and breathed for me.'

By a bold, almost desperate march, I passed through Cromwell's army, and entered England. The Protector set out in pursuit of this strange flight, which had a crown for its object. If I had been able to reach London before him, without doubt the prize of the race would have been mine; but he overtook me at Worcester.

The genius of England was no longer with us, but with him. On the 3rd of September, 1651, sire, the anniversary of the other battle of Dunbar, so fatal to the Scots, I was conquered. Two thousand men fell around me before I thought of retreating a step. At length I was obliged to fly.

From that moment my history became a romance. Pursued with persistent inveteracy, I cut off my hair, I disguised myself as a woodman. One day spent amidst the branches of an oak gave to that tree the name of the royal oak, which it bears to this day. My adventures in the county of Stafford, whence I escaped with the daughter of my host on a pillion behind me, still fill the tales of the country firesides, and would furnish matter for ballads. I will some day write all this, sire, for the instruction of my brother kings.

I will first tell how, on arriving at the residence of Mr. Norton, I met with a court chaplain, who was looking on at a party playing at skittles, and an old servant who named me, bursting into tears, and who was as near and as certainly killing me by his fidelity as another might have been by treachery. Then I will tell of my terrors—yes, sire, of my terrors—when, at the house of Colonel Windham, a farrier who came to shoe our horses declared they had been shod in the north.'

‘How strange!’ murmured Louis XIV ‘I never heard anything of all that; I was only told of your embarkation at Brighelmstone¹ and your landing in Normandy.’

‘Oh!’ exclaimed Charles, ‘if Heaven permits kings to be thus ignorant of the histories of each other, how can they render assistance to their brothers who need it?’

‘But tell me,’ continued Louis XIV, ‘how, after being so roughly received in England, you can still hope for anything from that unhappy country and that rebellious people?’

‘Oh, sire! since the battle of Worcester, everything is changed there. Cromwell is dead, after having signed a treaty with France, in which his name is placed above yours. He died on the 3rd of September, 1658, a fresh anniversary of the battles of Dunbar and Worcester.’

‘His son has succeeded him.’

‘But certain men have a family, sire, and no heir. The inheritance of Oliver was too heavy for Richard. Richard was neither a republican nor a royalist; Richard allowed his guards to eat his dinner, and his generals to govern the republic; Richard abdicated the protectorate on the 22nd of April, 1659, more than a year ago, sire.

From that time England is nothing but a tennis-court, in which the players throw dice for the crown of my father. The two most eager players are Lambert and Monk. Well, sire, I, in my turn, wish to take part in this game, where the stakes are thrown upon my royal mantle. Sire, it only requires a million to corrupt one of these players and make an ally of him, or two hundred of your gentlemen to drive them out of my palace at Whitehall, as Christ drove the money-changers from the temple.’

‘You come, then,’ replied Louis XIV, ‘to ask me—’

‘For your assistance; that is to say, not only for that which kings owe to each other, but that which simple Christians owe to each other—your assistance, sire, either in money or men. Your assistance, sire, and within a month, whether I oppose Lambert to Monk, or Monk to Lambert, I shall have reconquered my paternal inheritance, without having cost my country a guinea, or my subjects a drop of blood, for they are now all drunk with revolutions, protectorates, and republics, and ask nothing

¹The correct name of the city is Brighelmstone. The mistake is Dumas’s.

During this conversation, Louis XIV, conducted by Madame, accomplished, as we have described, the circle of presentations.

‘Mademoiselle Auricule,’ said the princess, presenting to his majesty a fat, fair girl of two-and-twenty, who at a village fete might have been taken for a peasant in Sunday finery,—‘the daughter of my music-mistress.’

The king smiled. Madame had never been able to extract four correct notes from either viol or harpsichord.

‘Mademoiselle Aure de Montalais,’ continued Madame; ‘a young lady of rank, and my good attendant.’

This time it was not the king that smiled; it was the young lady presented, because, for the first time in her life, she heard, given to her by Madame, who generally showed no tendency to spoil her, such an honourable qualification.

Our old acquaintance Montalais, therefore, made his majesty a profound courtesy, the more respectful from the necessity she was under of concealing certain contractions of her laughing lips, which the king might not have attributed to their real cause.

It was just at this moment that the king caught the word which startled him.

‘And the name of the third?’ asked Monsieur.

‘Mary, monseigneur,’ replied the cardinal.

There was doubtless some magical influence in that word, for, as we have said, the king started in hearing it, and drew Madame towards the middle of the circle, as if he wished to put some confidential question to her, but, in reality, for the sake of getting nearer to the cardinal.

‘Madame, my aunt,’ said he, laughing, and in a suppressed voice, ‘my geography-master did not teach me that Blois was at such an immense distance from Paris.’

‘What do you mean, nephew?’ asked Madame.

‘Why, because it would appear that it requires several years, as regards fashion, to travel the distance!—Look at those young ladies!’

‘Well; I know them all.’

‘Some of them are pretty.’

‘Don’t say that too loud, monsieur my nephew; you will drive them wild.’

Louis XIV had accomplished about a third of his review when his ears were struck with a word which his eminence pronounced whilst conversing with Monsieur.

This word was the name of a woman.

Scarcely had Louis XIV heard this word than he heard, or rather listening to nothing else; and neglecting the arc of the circle which awaited his visit, his object seemed to be to come as quickly as possible to the extremity of the curve.

Monsieur, like a good courtier, was inquiring of monsieur le cardinal after the health of his nieces; he regretted, he said, not having the pleasure of receiving them at the same time with their uncle; they must certainly have grown in stature, beauty and grace, as they had promised to do the last time Monsieur had seen them.

What had first struck the king was a certain constraint in the voices of the two interlocutors. The voice of Monsieur was calm and natural when he spoke thus; while that of M. de Mazarin jumped by a note and a half to reply above the diapason of his usual voice. It might have been said that he wished that voice to strike, at the end of the salon, any ear that was too distant.

'Monseigneur,' replied he, 'Mesdemoiselles de Mazarin have still to finish their education: they have duties to fulfil, and a position to make. An abode in a young and brilliant court would dissipate them a little.'

Louis, at this last sentence, smiled sadly. The court was young; it was true, but the avarice of the cardinal had taken good care that it should not be brilliant.

'You have nevertheless no intention,' replied Monsieur, 'to cloister them or make them bourgeois?'

'Not at all,' replied the cardinal, forcing his Italian pronunciation in such a manner that, from soft and velvety as it was, it became sharp and vibrating; 'not at all: I have a full and fixed intention to marry them, and that as well as I shall be able.'

'Parties will not be wanting, monsieur le cardinal,' replied Monsieur, with a bonhomie worthy of one tradesman congratulating another.

'I hope not, monseigneur, and with reason, as God has been pleased to give them grace, intelligence, and beauty.'

better than to fall staggering to sleep in the arms of royalty. Your assistance, sire, and I shall owe you more than I owe my father,—my poor father, who bought at so dear a rate the ruin of our house! You may judge, sire, whether I am unhappy, whether I am in despair, for I accuse my own father!

And the blood mounted to the pale face of Charles II, who remained for an instant with his head between his hands, and as if blinded by that blood which appeared to revolt against the filial blasphemy.

The young king was not less affected than his elder brother; he threw himself about in his fauteuil, and could not find a single word of reply.

Charles II, to whom ten years in age gave a superior strength to master his emotions, recovered his speech the first.

'Sire,' said he, 'your reply? I wait for it as a criminal waits for his sentence. Must I die?'

'My brother,' replied the French prince, 'you ask of me for a million—me, who was never possessed of a quarter of that sum! I possess nothing. I am no more king of France than you are king of England. I am a name, a cipher dressed in fleur-de-lised velvet,—that is all. I am upon a visible throne; that is my only advantage over your majesty. I have nothing—I can do nothing.'

'Can it be so?' exclaimed Charles II.

'My brother,' said Louis, sinking his voice, 'I have undergone miseries with which my poorest gentlemen are unacquainted. If my poor Laporte were here, he would tell you that I have slept in ragged sheets, through the holes of which my legs have passed; he would tell you that afterwards, when I asked for carriages, they brought me conveyances half-destroyed by the rats of the coach-houses; he would tell you that when I asked for my dinner, the servants went to the cardinal's kitchen to inquire if there were any dinner for the king. And look! to-day, this very day even, when I am twenty-two years of age,—to-day, when I have attained the grade of the majority of kings,—to-day, when I ought to have the key of the treasury, the direction of the policy, the supremacy in peace and war,—cast your eyes around me, see how I am left! Look at this abandonment—this disdain—this silence!—Whilst yonder—look yonder! View the bustle, the lights, the homage! There!—there you see the real king of France, my brother!'

'In the cardinal's apartments?'

'Yes, in the cardinal's apartments.'

'Then I am condemned, sire?'

Louis XIV made no reply.

'Condemned is the word; for I will never solicit him who left my mother and sister to die with cold and hunger—the daughter and grand-daughter of Henry IV—as surely they would have if M. de Retz and the parliament had not sent them wood and bread.'

'To die?' murmured Louis XIV

'Well!' continued the king of England, 'poor Charles II, grandson of Henry IV, as you are, sire having neither parliament nor Cardinal de Retz to apply to, will die of hunger, as his mother and sister had nearly done.'

Louis knitted his brow, and twisted violently the lace of his ruffles.

This prostration, this immobility, serving as a mark to an emotion so visible, struck Charles II, and he took the young man's hand.

'Thanks!' said he, 'my brother. You pity me, and that is all I can require of you in your present situation.'

'Sire,' said Louis XIV, with a sudden impulse, and raising his head, 'it is a million you require, or two hundred gentlemen, I think you say?'

'Sire, a million would be quite sufficient.'

'That is very little.'

'Offered to a single man it is a great deal. Convictions have been purchased at a much lower price; and I should have nothing to do but with venalities.'

'Two hundred gentlemen! Reflect!—that is little more than a single company.'

'Sire, there is in our family a tradition, and that is, that four men, four French gentlemen, devoted to my father, were near saving my father, though condemned by a parliament, guarded by an army and surrounded by a nation.'

'Then if I can procure you a million, or two hundred gentlemen, you will be satisfied; and you will consider me your well-affectioned brother?'

'I shall consider you as my saviour; and if I recover the throne of my father, England will be, as long as I reign it, a sister to France, as you will have been a brother to me.'

The king remarked that his mother and he scarcely knew the names of any of the persons who were presented to them; whilst the cardinal, on the contrary, never failed, with an admirable memory and presence of mind, to talk to every one about his estates, his ancestors, or his children, some of whom he named, which enchanted those worthy country gentlemen, and confirmed them in the idea that he alone is truly king who knows his subjects, from the same reason that the sun has no rival, because the sun alone warms and lightens.

The study of the young king, which had begun a long time before, without anybody suspecting it, was continued then, and he looked around him attentively to endeavour to make out something in the physiognomies which had at first appeared the most insignificant and trivial.

A collation was served. The king, without daring to call upon the hospitality of his uncle, had waited for it impatiently. This time, therefore, he had all the honours due, if not to his rank, at least to his appetite.

As to the cardinal, he contented himself with touching with his withered lips a bouillon, served in a golden cup. The all-powerful minister, who had taken her regency from the queen, and his royalty from the king, had not been able to take a good stomach from nature.

Anne of Austria, already suffering from the cancer which six or eight years after caused her death, ate very little more than the cardinal.

For Monsieur, already puffed up with the great event which had taken place in his provincial life, he ate nothing whatever.

Madame alone, like a true Lorrainer, kept pace with his majesty; so that Louis XIV, who, without this partner, might have eaten nearly alone, was at first much pleased with his aunt, and afterwards with M. de Saint-Remy, her maître d'hôtel, who had really distinguished himself.

The collation over, at a sign of approbation from M. de Mazarin, the king arose, and, at the invitation of his aunt, walked about among the ranks of the assembly.

The ladies then observed—there are certain things for which women are as good observers at Blois as at Paris—the ladies then observed that Louis XIV had a prompt and bold look, which premised a distinguished appreciator of beauty. The men, on their part, observed that the prince was proud and haughty, that he loved to look down those who fixed their eyes upon him too long or too earnestly, which gave presage of a master.